

Eero Saarinen

The son of an influential Finnish architect, Eero Saarinen (1910–61) worked for most of his life in the United States. After spending the Second World War designing for the military, he took over the family firm in Michigan, creating buildings that blended his father's Art Deco style with his own modernist ideas. The result was a simple but rich sculptural approach offering more visual drama than the austerity of the international style.

Among several prestigious buildings, Saarinen designed the TWA Flight Centre (1956–62) at John F. Kennedy Airport in New York, the Kresge Auditorium at MIT in Massachusetts (opposite, 1953–5) and the Jefferson National Expansion Memorial in Missouri (1947–66, including the iconic Gateway Arch). Many feature his characteristic thin-shelled concrete curves, steel, large amounts of glass and minimal interior supports. Alongside his architectural work, Saarinen became equally renowned as a designer of modernist furniture.

